

Research Workshop Spring 2026

“Writing”

Part 3: Build an Outline

CEMFI

Method: 3 Layers

- **Positioning:** articulate a concise argument about what knowledge the paper contributes
- **Outline:** build an outline to support this argument
- **Paragraphs:** linking the points of the outline

Build an Outline

- Readers should be able to infer a paper's argument (its RAP) from the abstract and first couple paragraphs of the Introduction
- How is the argument supported by the rest of the paper?
- Help the reader to navigate through the paper.
- **Headings:** A heading is the title for a particular chunk of text.
 - A reader looking at the title should be able to see where the main question/arguments are
- **Takeaways:** a mini paragraph – a few concise and meaningful sentences at the beginning of each section
 - If a reader goes beyond the heading, they should have an idea what these questions/arguments are

Headings

1. Introduction

2. What factors determine labor market returns to education?

2.1 The role of connections for job market applicants

2.2 Definition of key concepts

VS.

1. Introduction

2. Fixing concepts

2.1 A missing link in the literature: *connectedness*

2.2 Terminology

Example

- "A New Measure of Monetary Shocks: Derivation and Implications" (Romer and Romer).
- *RAP: We argue with a new improved measure of the U.S. monetary policy shocks, we can see the effect of monetary policy is stronger than is found.*
- *What questions are provoked?*
 - *What is the new improved measure?*
 - *How do you see that the effect of monetary policy is stronger?*
 - *See Sections I and II of the paper*

Example

follow-up questions:

"We argue that with a new, better measure of US monetary policy shocks, we can see that the effect of monetary policy is stronger than is found through conventional measures."

What is this new, better measure?

How do you see that the effect of monetary policy is stronger?

The two major sections of the paper are set up to answer these two questions:

I. Derivation of a New Measure of Monetary Policy Shocks

The derivation of our new measure of monetary policy shocks has two key steps. The first is to derive a series for Federal Reserve intentions for the federal funds rate around FOMC meetings. The second is to control for Federal Reserve forecasts, and so create a measure of intended monetary policy actions not driven by information about future economic developments.

A. Changes in the Intended Federal Funds Rate around FOMC Meetings

Motivation.—The Greenbook forecasts are only done before FOMC meetings. Therefore,

II. Implications of the New Measure

The next step in our analysis is to use the new measure of monetary policy shocks to estimate the effects of policy. We first examine the impact of policy on output and on prices in simple, single-equation regressions. We then examine the impact of policy in a single-equation framework with an explicit control for supply shocks, and in a vector autoregression framework.

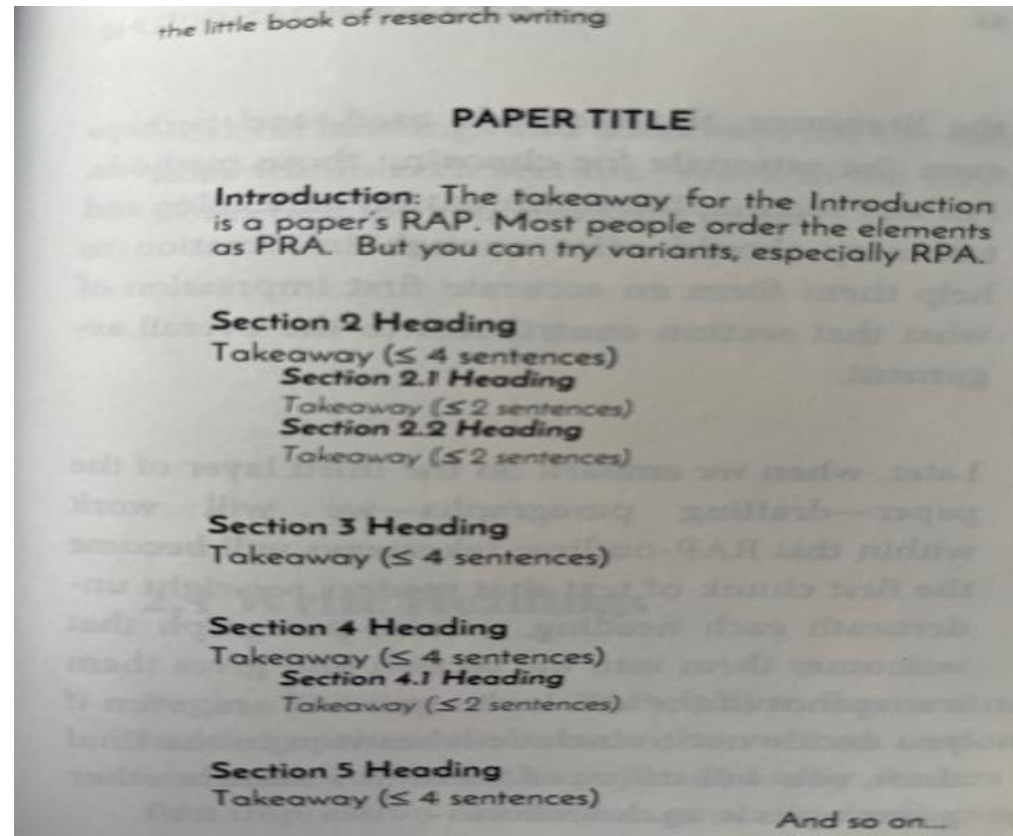
A. Output

Methodology.—We want to determine how output behaves in the wake of monetary shocks. The obvious way to do this is simply to regress current growth on a constant, its own lagged

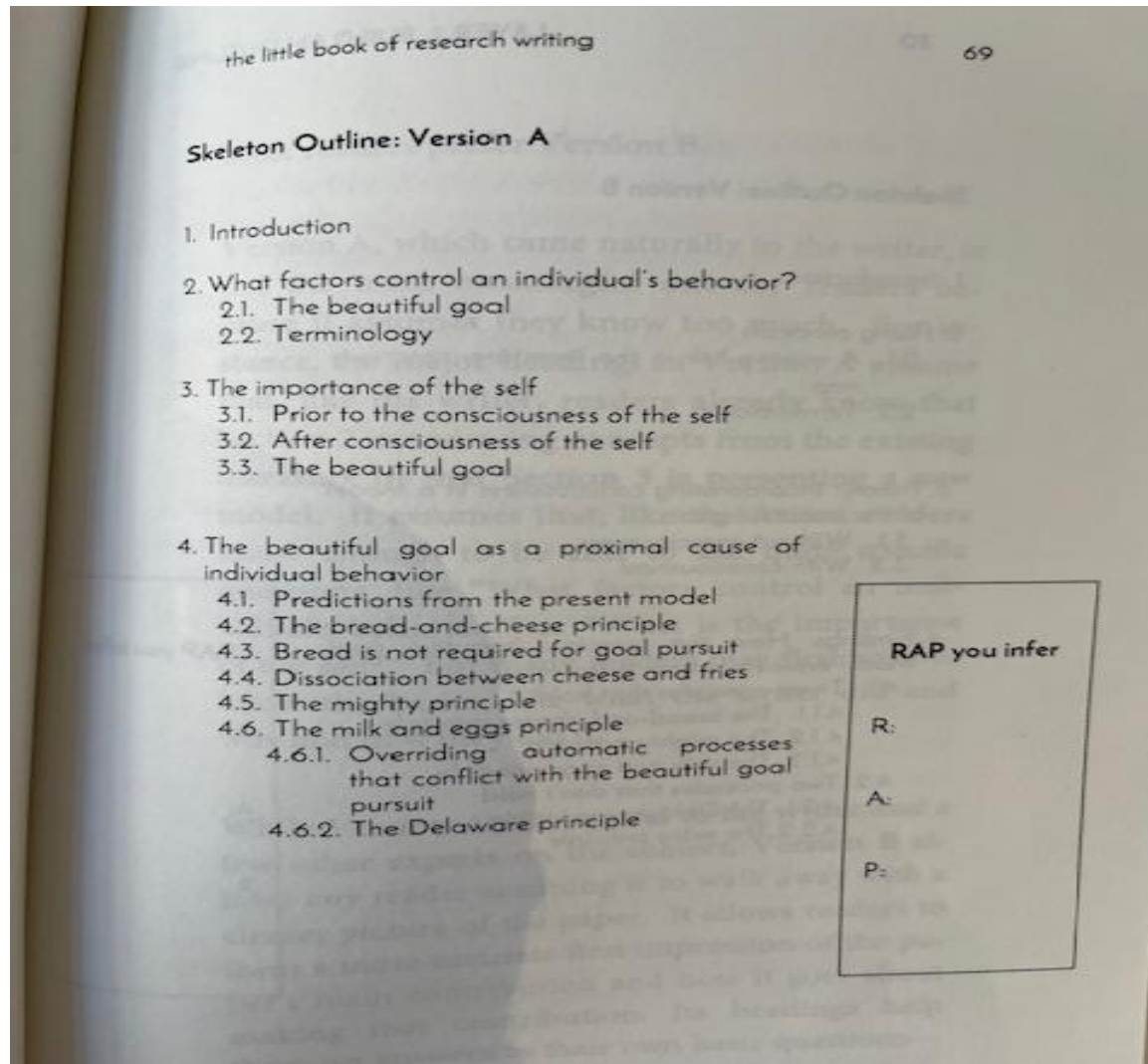
This helps readers recognize that the paper is organized to develop the argument: section

Headings

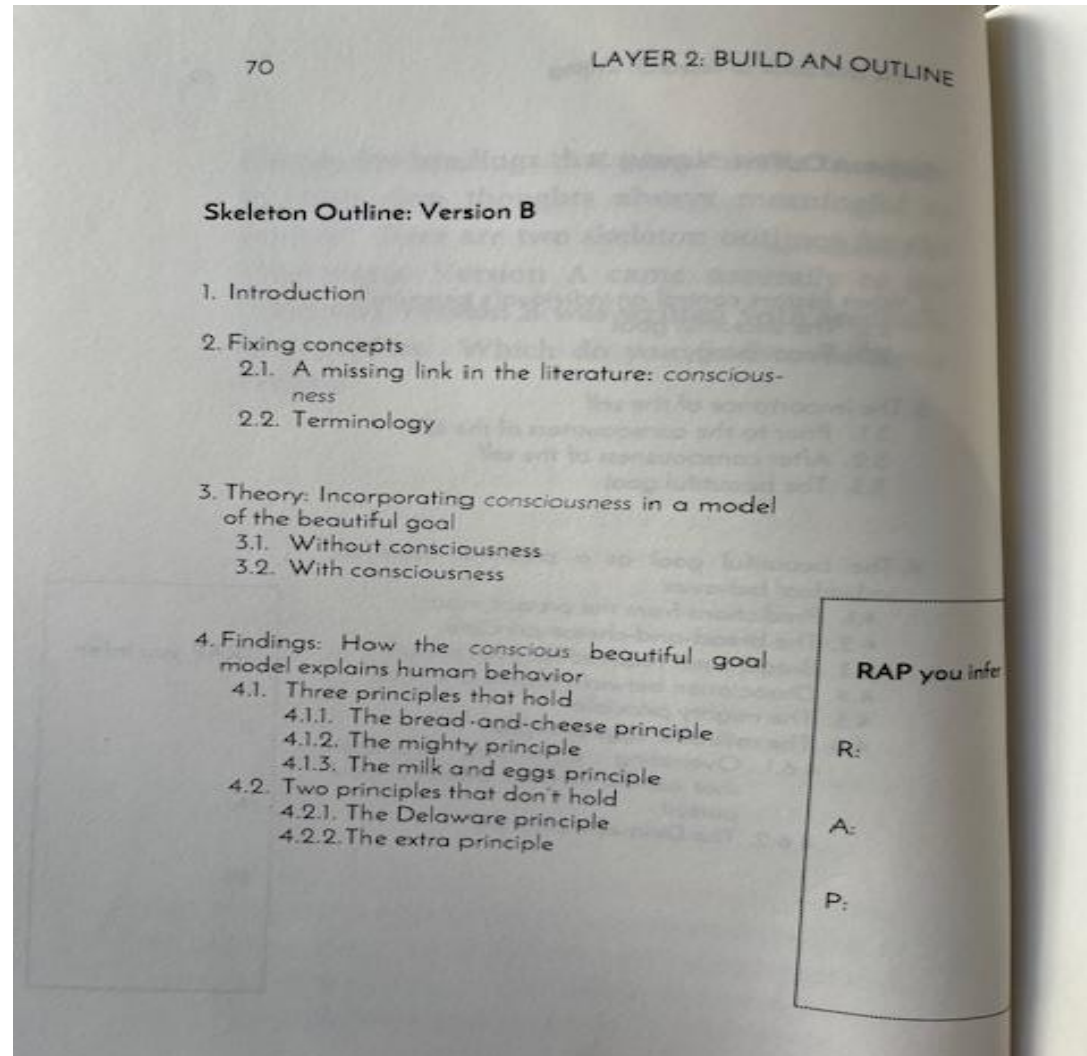
- The skeleton of the paper isn't just to organize your own thoughts, but the reader's as well
- Hence feedback is key to making sure you are understandable



Example A



Example B



Tips for Headings

- **Keywords:** what your readers can remember
 - Be consistent
 - Be specific “model X with two departures”
- **Order:** by logical flow
 - Many conflicting opinions, iterate feedback up to a point
 - e.g., method 1 + results 1, method 2 +results 2 or methods and then results
- **Skim similar papers:** their structure is informative

Exercise

- List the general questions coming up from your own RAP
- Your list (expert) vs. another person's list (general reader)
- What is common?
- What is different?

Follow-up Questions from RAP?

the little book of research writing 75

Some examples of questions different types of readers may have

Any-reader	Expert-reader
How do you go about developing your argument?	How is this different from X's argument?
What methods do you use?	How does this relate to my work?
How does Section 3 connect to Section 4?	Isn't Y a more appropriate method?
Having seen X, I expect to see Y. Where can I find it?	Why is assumption B a reasonable assumption to make?
Why is assumption B a reasonable assumption to make?	But what about Z?
How are your findings relevant outside the specific context in which you find them?	So based on your work, what would we make of question C?
What are the implications of your work? How does it change how things are done in research or elsewhere?	

Building Your Outline

- Put the RAP on the top
- What questions were provoked by the RAP?
- Draft the headings based on it
- For each section, write takeaways
- Share your outline with a classmate
 - What's the paper's argument? (without reading the RAP first)
 - What questions come to mind from the RAP?
 - Do they know where to find their answers?
 - Does the logical flow make sense?

Takeaways

- Main **message** of the section (for general audience)
- **Connects** to the overall argument of the paper
- **Prepare** the reader to absorb the details that follow
- Length
 - Intro: the RAP (usually PRA, or RPA)
 - Sections: less than 4 concise and meaningful sentences
 - Subsections: less than 2 concise and meaningful sentences

How to connect to overall argument

- **Directly:** to the RAP
 - To study [R], we use reform...
 - The model is similar to... with one key difference...
- **Indirectly:** through another section
 - We use data... that allows us to implement the strategy...
 - We just saw that... Next, we will show... and in the next subsection...

Takeaways - Example

B. Asymmetrical Information

It has been seen that the good cars may be driven out of the market by the lemons. But in a more continuous case with different grades of goods, even worse pathologies can exist. For it is quite possible to have the bad driving out the not-so-bad driving out the medium driving out the not-so-good driving out the good in such a sequence of events that no market exists at all.⁸

⁸ From Akerlof, G. (1970). The Market for "Lemons": Quality Uncertainty and the Market Mechanism. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 84(3), p.488.

After Takeaways

- For each takeaway
- Write 3 **questions** that the following paragraphs should address.